

Khelo India and Khelo University Games initiatives delivered?

These games have improved talent identification, increased participation at the grassroots level, and spurred infrastructure development. They have also provided athletes with valuable competition exposure and improved facilities during the games.

We have also planned the Khelo India School Games, City Games, and Beach Games.

Khelo India has established itself as a brand. A prime example is the participation of 28 Khelo India athletes in the Paris 2024 Olympic Games and 41 medallists in the 2022 Asian Games.

We also have the Kirti programme for talent identification. Our team goes and analyses the children and then we support the best players from there.

Are there any programmes to support the girl child in sports? Are there special schemes to discover and train young girls in rural India?

Yes, schemes like Khelo India ASMITA (Sports for Women), all-women SAI training centres such as the one in Dharamsala, and targeted talent scouting programmes aim to identify and nurture rural girls. Special coaching camps and mentorship programmes are also being expanded. Our daughters are performing exceptionally well at present — our girls are winning more medals at the Olympics and the Asian Games. Even our para-athletes are doing well. And this number is only going to increase.

A 33% reservation will also be introduced for women coaches to ensure greater participation of women. There will also be reservation in administrative roles.

How will the RESET (Retired Sportspersons Empowerment Training) programme support post-retirement transitions of athletes?

RESET is an idea with multiple possibilities. It aims to offer retired athletes skill development, career counselling, and financial planning

support, ensuring they have viable pathways into post-sport careers and improved financial security. More work is needed in this area to create employment opportunities for retiring athletes.

Apart from sports-related jobs like coaching, sports scientists may be developed through RESET as it progresses into other areas such as sports management, professional sports leagues, and the fitness industry.

Recruitment under the sports quota has declined in PSUs and government departments. Should entities like the Railways be mandated to reserve more positions for athletes?

Increasing reserved positions in PSUs like the Railways could enhance career opportunities for athletes. However, any mandate should be designed in consultation with stakeholders to balance both requirements and representation.

Under RESET, different certification courses of six months and three months are being conducted, which can help former athletes seek employment in private institutes or with the government. They can also work in federations or train children — this could be a huge factor in increasing the number of coaches.

India's topography is ideal for high-altitude training centres, yet we have just one centre in Himachal Pradesh. Why hasn't this potential been tapped, and are there plans to expand such facilities?

Historically, budgetary and logistical challenges have limited the development of such facilities. High-altitude centres are primarily meant for endurance training. However, there are alternative solutions, such as hypoxic chambers, which simulate high-altitude conditions. Innovations like these may pave the way forward, improving the efficiency and efficacy of high-altitude training.

Given your interest in sports science, how do you intend to use

it to further enhance India's sporting potential?

The focus is on integrating sports science into athlete training, injury prevention, and performance analysis. Collaborations with global experts, increased research funding, and technology-driven interventions will be prioritised.

Despite large-scale recruitment by SAI, concerns remain about the qualifications of coaches and support staff. Does India have the human resources needed for elite athlete development, and how do you plan to address the gaps?

Sport is on the rise, and so is the requirement for a qualified workforce. We need to improve the athlete-to-coach ratio, which currently stands at around 1:8, 1:10, or 1:15. Although recruitment has expanded, there remains a need to upskill coaches and support staff.

The SAI and NSFs are continuously working to upgrade coaches through certification courses at various levels. Peripheral knowledge in sports science areas — such as Strength & Conditioning, nutrition, etc.— is also imparted. SAI NSNIS Patiala hosts multiple such courses. Recently, a 'Yoga for Peak Performance' course was conducted in March 2025. Focused training, certification programmes, and international collaborations are being implemented to bridge these gaps.

Additionally, all NSFs have been encouraged to hire High-Performance Directors to design and oversee the development of their respective sporting disciplines from grassroots to elite levels. State governments must also do more to upskill their workforce in this area.

Until more children start playing sport, the demand for coaches will not increase. To meet this future demand, it is necessary to introduce some changes.

I have put a proposal to our ministry that we should start expanding professional courses in sports science, as very few universities offer them right now. We need to introduce courses on sports science, sports medicine, sports